Introduction to Mathematics and Physics

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Abstract

This is a simple abstract for the Introduction to Mathematics and Physics notes. It provides an overview of the topics covered in the course.

1 Lecture 1

2 Lecture 2

2.1 Introduction and the Geometric Picture

2.1.1 Basic definition

Definition 2.1

An ordinary differential equation (ODE) of order n is an equation of the form

$$F\left(x, y, y', \ldots, y^{(n)}\right) = 0,$$

where $y = y(x)$ is an unknown function and primes denote derivatives with respect to x.

Definition 2.2

A solution on an interval I is a function

$$y\colon I \to \mathbb{R}$$

that is n time differentiable and satisfies the differential equation for all $x \in I$.

Definition 2.3

The initial value problem (IVP) for an ordinary differential equation of order n is an equation of the form

$$F\left(x, y, y', \ldots, y^{(n)}\right) = 0,$$

together with initial conditions

$$y(x_0) = y_0, \quad y'(x_0) = y_1, \quad \ldots, \quad y^{(n-1)}(x_0) = y_{n-1},$$

where $x_0 \in I$ and $y_0, y_1, \ldots, y_{n-1} \in \mathbb{R}$.

Remark

For first-order ordinary differential equations

$$y' = f(x, y)$$

the initial value problem takes the form

$$y' = f(x, y), \quad y(x_0) = y_0$$

Example

Consider the first-order ordinary differential equation

$$y' = -y, \quad y(0) = 3.$$

The solution to this initial value problem is

$$y(x) = 3e^{-x}.$$

2.1.2 Direction Fields

The equation

$$y' = f(x, y)$$

shows that for each point (x, y) in the plane, the slope that any solution curve passing through that point must have, given by $f(x, y)$.

We can represent this information graphically using a direction field, where at each point (x, y) in the plane, we draw a small line segment with the slope $f(x, y)$.

Definition 2.4

A direction field (or slope field) for the first-order differential equation

$$y' = f(x, y)$$

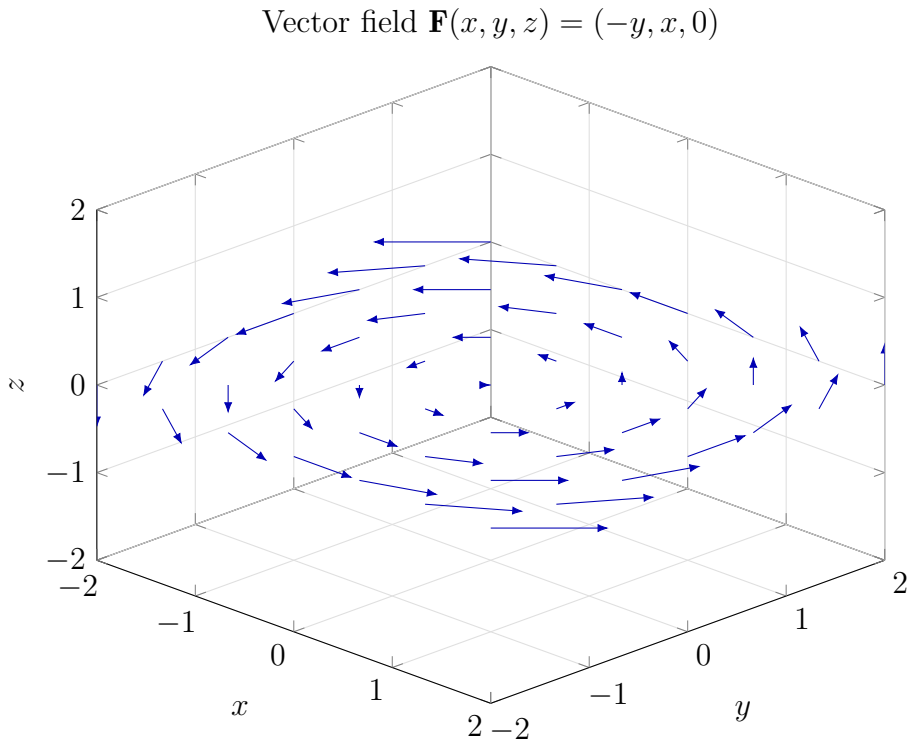
is a graphical representation where at each point (x, y) in the plane, a small line segment is drawn with the slope $f(x, y)$.

Solutions to the differential equation can be visualized as curves that are tangent everywhere to the line segments in the direction field.

Remark

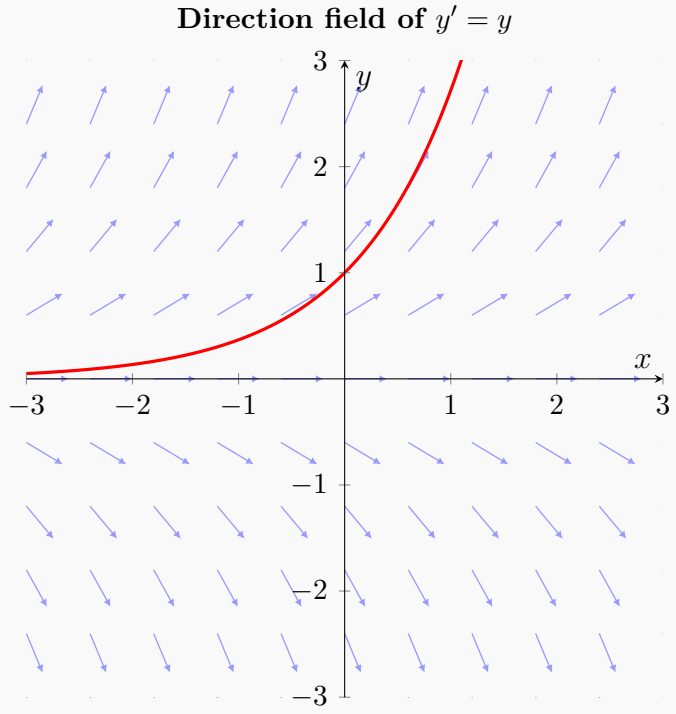
Geometric Principle

Through each point (x, y) in the plane, there should be exactly one solution curve passing through it. Provided f is well-behaved (continuous and satisfies the Lipschitz condition) near the point (x, y). The Existence and Uniqueness Theorem make this principle precise.



Example

For $y' = y$, the direction field consists of line segments with slope equal to the value of y at each point (x, y) in the plane.



2.2 Existence and Uniqueness

2.2.1 Motivation

Before spending time solving IVPs, we should ask whether a solution exists and whether it is unique.

Example

Consider the initial value problem

$$y' = y^{1/3}, \quad y(0) = 0.$$

The solution of this initial value problem is

$$y = \left(\frac{2}{3}x\right)^{3/2}.$$

And

$$y = 0.$$

Which is not unique.

2.2.2 The Picard-Lindelöf Theorem

Definition 2.5

Lipschitz Continuous

There exists a constant $L > 0$ such that

$$|f(x, y_1) - f(x, y_2)| \leq L|y_1 - y_2| \quad \forall (x, y_1), (x, y_2) \in D.$$

Theorem 2.1

Picard-Lindelöf Theorem (Existence and Uniqueness)

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let $f(x, y)$ be defined on a rectangle D, suppose:

1. $f(x, y)$ is continuous on D.
2. $f(x, y)$ is Lipschitz continuous in y on D.

Then there exists $h > 0$ such that the initial value problem

$$y' = f(x, y), \quad y(x_0) = y_0$$

has a unique solution $y(x)$ on the interval $|x - x_0| < h$.

Remark

A sufficient condition for the Lipschitz condition is that the partial derivative of f with respect to y exists and is bounded on D.

$$L = \sup_D \left| \frac{\partial f}{\partial y} \right|$$

2.2.3 proof scetch

Definition 2.6

sequence of functions defined by the Picard iteration:

$$y_0(x) = y_0, \quad y_{n+1}(x) = y_0 + \int_{x_0}^{x} f(t, y_n(t))\, dt.$$

Each y_{n+1} is obtained by plugging the previous approximation into the right-hand side.

Key steps of the proof:

1. **Well-definedness.** If y_n stays in D, continuity of f ensures y_{n+1} is well defined and differentiable.

2. **Convergence.** Using the Lipschitz condition, one shows

$$|y_{n+1}(x) - y_n(x)| \leq \frac{ML^n |x - x_0|^{n+1}}{(n+1)!},$$

where $M = \sup_D |f|$. This is the n-th term of the series for $Me^{L|x-x_0|}/L$, so the series $(y_{n+1} - y_n)$ converges absolutely and uniformly on $|x - x_0| \leq h$ for h small enough.

3. **Limit is a solution.** Uniform convergence justifies passing the limit inside the integral; the limit function satisfies the integral equation, hence the IVP.

4. **Uniqueness.** If y and z are two solutions, then $u = y - z$ satisfies

$$|u(x)| \leq L \int |u(t)|\, dt.$$

Gronwall's inequality then forces $u \equiv 0$.

Example

(Picard iteration for $y' = y$, $y(0) = 1$)

$$
\begin{aligned}
y_0(x) &= 1, \\
y_1(x) &= 1 + \int_0^x y_0(t)\,dt = 1 + \int_0^x 1\,dt = 1 + x, \\
y_2(x) &= 1 + \int_0^x y_1(t)\,dt = 1 + \int_0^x (1 + t)\,dt = 1 + x + \frac{x^2}{2}, \\
y_3(x) &= 1 + \int_0^x y_2(t)\,dt = 1 + \int_0^x \left(1 + t + \frac{t^2}{2}\right) dt = 1 + x + \frac{x^2}{2} + \frac{x^3}{6}, \\
&\vdots \\
y_n(x) &\to e^x \text{ as } n \to \infty.
\end{aligned}
$$

The partial sums if e^x emerge. The sequence converges to $y(x) = e^x$.

2.3 Separable Equations

Definition 2.7

A first-order ODE is called **separable** if $f(x, y)$ can be factored as a product of a function of x and a function of y.

So it can be written in the form

$$\frac{dy}{dx} = g(x)h(y),$$

where g and h are continuous functions.

The main idea of solving separable equations is separating the variables and integrating both sides.

1. Write the equation as $\dfrac{dy}{h(y)} = g(x)\,dx$ (formally separate variables).
2. Integrate both sides: $\displaystyle\int \frac{dy}{h(y)} = \int g(x)\,dx + C$.
3. Solve for y if possible (explicit solution); otherwise leave implicit.
4. Apply any initial condition to determine C.
5. Check for *equilibrium solutions* $h(y) = 0$ that may have been lost when dividing.

Remark

When we divide by $h(y)$, we implicitly assume $h(y) \neq 0$. Any constant value $y = c$ where $h(c) = 0$ is a solution (an *equilibrium solution*) and must be checked separately.

2.4 Substitution method

2.4.1 Homogeneous Equations

Definition 2.8

A first-order ODE is called **homogeneous** if it can be written in the form

$$\frac{dy}{dx} = f\left(\frac{y}{x}\right)$$

For some function f.

The substitution $v = \frac{y}{x}$ (hence $y = vx$) can be used to transform it into a separable equation.

1. Verify the equation has the form $y' = F(y/x)$.
2. Substitute $v = y/x$, so $y = vx$ and $y' = v + xv'$.
3. The equation becomes $v + xv' = F(v)$, i.e. $x\frac{\mathrm{dv}}{\mathrm{dx}} = F(v) - v$, which is **separable** in v and x.
4. Solve for $v(x)$, then back-substitute $y = vx$.

2.4.2 Bernoulli Equations

Definition 2.9

A first-order ODE is called a **Bernoulli equation** if it can be written in the form

$$\frac{dy}{dx} + P(x)y = Q(x)y^n,$$

where $n \neq 0, 1$ and P and Q are continuous functions. (If $n = 0$ or $n = 1$, the equation is linear or separable, respectively.)

The substitution $v = y^{1-n}$ (hence $y = v^{\frac{1}{1-n}}$) can be used to transform it into a linear equation.

1. Divide through by y^n: $\quad y^{-n}y' + P(x)y^{1-n} = Q(x)$.
2. Substitute $w = y^{1-n}$, so $w' = (1-n)y^{-n}y'$.
3. The equation becomes the **first-order linear** equation

$$\frac{w'}{1-n} + P(x)w = Q(x), \quad \text{i.e.} \quad w' + (1-n)P(x)w = (1-n)Q(x).$$

4. Solve for $w(x)$, then recover $y = w^{1/(1-n)}$.

3 Lecture 3

3.1 First Order Linear Equations

Definition 3.1

A first-order linear equation is an ODE of the form

$$\frac{dy}{dx} + P(x)y = Q(x),$$

where P and Q are continuous functions.

- The equation is called homogeneous if $Q \equiv 0$.
- The equation is called non-homogeneous (or inhomogeneous) otherwise.

Remark

In this context, "homogeneous" means $|Q| = 0$, not the "F (y/x)" sense.

3.1.1 Homogeneous Equations

The homogeneous first-order linear equation is of the form

$$\frac{dy}{dx} + P(x)y = 0.$$

Which is separable.

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{dy}{dx} &= -P(x)y, \\
\frac{dy}{y} &= -P(x)dx. \\
\int \frac{dy}{y} &= \int -P(x)dx. \\
\ln|y| &= -\int P(x)dx + C, \\
y &= Ce^{-\int P(x)dx}.
\end{aligned}$$

where C is an arbitrary constant. This is the complementary solution (or homogeneous solution) y_h.

Theorem 3.1

Superposition principle

Structure of the general solution of a first-order linear equation If y_p is a particular solution of the non-homogeneous equation

$$\frac{dy}{dx} + P(x)y = Q(x),$$

then the general solution is

$$y = y_h + y_p,$$

where y_h is the complementary solution of the corresponding homogeneous equation.

Verify this by substituting $y = y_h + y_p$ into the original non-homogeneous equation.

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{d}{dx}(y_h + y_p) + P(x)(y_h + y_p) &= \frac{dy_h}{dx} + \frac{dy_p}{dx} + P(x)y_h + P(x)y_p \\
&= \underbrace{\frac{dy_h}{dx} + P(x)y_h}_{=0} + \frac{dy_p}{dx} + P(x)y_p \\
&= \frac{dy_p}{dx} + P(x)y_p \\
&= Q(x).
\end{aligned}$$

The superposition principle states that the general solution of a non-homogeneous first-order linear equation is the sum of the complementary solution and a particular solution. It is a fundamental feature of all linear equations and has no analogue for nonlinear ones.

3.2 The Method of Integrating Factor

3.2.1 Definition

We want μ such that

$$\mu(x)[y' + P(x)y] = [\mu(x)y]'.$$

Expanding the right side

$$[\mu y]' = \mu' y + \mu y'$$

Matching with the left side

$$\mu y' + \mu P y = \mu' y + \mu y' \implies \mu P = \mu',$$

so

$$\frac{\mu'}{\mu} = P(x) \implies \mu(x) = e^{\int P(x)\,dx}$$

Definition 3.2

The function

$$\mu(x) = e^{\int P(x)\,dx}$$

is the integrating factor for the first-order linear differential equation

$$y' + P(x)y = Q(x)$$

The general solution of the differential equation can be expressed as

$$y = \frac{1}{\mu(x)}\left(\int \mu(x)Q(x)\,dx + C\right),$$

where C is an arbitrary constant.

Proof. We start with the first-order linear differential equation

$$y' + P(x)y = Q(x).$$

Then multiply both sides of the differential equation by $\mu(x)$

$$\mu(x)[y' + P(x)y] = [\mu(x)y]'.$$

the general solution can then be found by integrating both sides with respect to x.

$$\begin{aligned}
&[\mu(x)y]' = \mu(x)Q(x) \\
&\mu(x)y = \int \mu(x)Q(x)\,dx + C \implies y = \frac{1}{\mu(x)}\left(\int \mu(x)Q(x)\,dx + C\right),
\end{aligned}$$

where C is an arbitrary constant.

$$y = \frac{1}{\mu(x)}\left(\int \mu(x)Q(x)\,dx + C\right)$$

□

3.2.2 Example

Example

Solve the first-order linear differential equation $y' + 2y = 4$, $y(0) = 1$.

$$P(x) = 2, \quad Q(x) = 4$$

The integrating factor is

$$\mu(x) = e^{\int 2\,dx} = e^{2x}.$$

Multiply both sides by $\mu(x)$

$$e^{2x}y' + 2e^{2x}y = 4e^{2x} \implies (e^{2x}y)' = 4e^{2x}.$$

Integrate both sides

$$e^{2x}y = \int 4e^{2x}\,dx + C = 2e^{2x} + C \implies y = 2 + Ce^{-2x}.$$

Applying the initial condition $y(0) = 1$,

$$y = 2 - e^{-2x}.$$

Example

Solve the first-order linear differential equation $y' + 2xy = x^2$, $y(1) = 0$ for $x > 0$.

$$P(x) = 2x, \quad Q(x) = x^2$$

The integrating factor is

$$\mu(x) = e^{\int 2x\,dx} = e^{x^2}.$$

Multiply both sides by $\mu(x)$

$$e^{x^2}y' + 2xe^{x^2}y = x^2e^{x^2} \implies (e^{x^2}y)' = x^2e^{x^2}.$$

Integrate both sides

$$e^{x^2}y = \int x^2e^{x^2}\,dx + C \implies y = e^{-x^2}\left(\int x^2e^{x^2}\,dx + C\right).$$

Applying the initial condition $y(1) = 0$,

$$0 = e^{-1}\left(\int_1^1 x^2e^{x^2}\,dx + C\right) \implies C = 0.$$

Therefore, the solution is

$$y = e^{-x^2}\int_1^x t^2e^{t^2}\,dt.$$

Remark

Algorithm for solving the first-order linear differential equation $y' + P(x)y = Q(x)$

1. Identify $P(x)$ and $Q(x)$ from the differential equation $y' + P(x)y = Q(x)$.
2. Compute the integrating factor $\mu(x) = e^{\int P(x)\,dx}$.
3. Multiply both sides by $\mu(x)$ to obtain $[\mu(x)y]' = \mu(x)Q(x)$.
4. Integrate both sides with respect to x

$$\mu(x)y = \int \mu(x)Q(x)\,dx + C$$

.

5. Solve for y by dividing both sides by $\mu(x)$

$$y = \frac{1}{\mu(x)}\left(\int \mu(x)Q(x)\,dx + C\right)$$

.

6. Apply initial conditions if given to determine the constant C.

3.2.3 Variation of Parameters

There is another approach to solving first-order linear differential equations called the method of variation of parameters.

Definition 3.3

The method of variation of parameters is a technique for finding a particular solution to a nonhomogeneous first-order linear differential equation of the form $y' + P(x)y = Q(x)$. The general solution is given by

$$y = y_h + y_p,$$

where y_h is the solution to the corresponding homogeneous equation $y' + P(x)y = 0$, and y_p is a particular solution found by assuming $y_p = u(x)y_h$ and determining $u(x)$ such that y_p satisfies the original nonhomogeneous equation.

We know the homogeneous solution is

$$y_h = Ae^{-\int P(x)\,dx}.$$

The idea: treat A as a functionof x and seek a particular solution $y_p = A(x)e^{-\int P(x)\,dx}$. Computing y_p' and substituting into

$$y' + P(x)y = Q(x)$$

we obtain an equation for $A'(x)$

$$A'(x)e^{-\int P(x)\,dx} = Q(x) \implies A'(x) = Q(x)e^{\int P(x)\,dx}.$$

Integrating both sides gives

$$A(x) = \int Q(x)e^{\int P(x)\,dx}\,dx.$$

Therefore, the particular solution is

$$y_p = A(x)e^{-\int P(x)\,dx} = e^{-\int P(x)\,dx}\int Q(x)e^{\int P(x)\,dx}\,dx.$$

3.3 Existence and Uniqueness of Differential Equations

3.3.1 The Sharper Theorem

Theorem 3.2

Suppose $P(x)$ and $Q(x)$ are continuous on an open interval I containing x_0. Then the IVP

$$y' + P(x)y = Q(x), \quad y(x_0) = y_0$$

has a unique solution $y(x)$ that exists for all $x \in I$.

Proof. The proof of this theorem relies on the method of integrating factors. Consider the differential equation

$$y' + P(x)y = Q(x), \quad y(x_0) = y_0.$$

The integrating factor

$$\mu(x) = e^{\int P(x)\,dx}$$

is well-defined and continuously differentiable on I (since P is continuous).
Then $\mu(x)Q(x)$ is continuous on I, so

$$H(x) = \int_{x_0}^{x} \mu(t)Q(t)\,dt$$

is a well-defined C^1 function on I.

$$\frac{d}{dx}\left(\mu(x)y\right) = \mu(x)Q(x)$$

Is Differentiable, and integrating both sides gives

$$\mu(x)y = \int \mu(x)Q(x)\,dx + C$$

$$y = \frac{1}{\mu(x)}\left(\int \mu(x)Q(x)\,dx + C\right).$$

And I needs to contain the initial condition $y(x_0) = y_0$ to determine the constant C.
Specifically, substituting $x = x_0$ and $y = y_0$ into the solution gives

$$y_0 = \frac{1}{\mu(x_0)}\left(\int_{x_0}^{x_0} \mu(t)Q(t)\,dt + C\right) = \frac{C}{\mu(x_0)} \implies C = y_0\mu(x_0).$$

Therefore, the unique solution satisfying the initial condition is

$$y = \frac{1}{\mu(x)}\left(\int_{x_0}^{x} \mu(t)Q(t)\,dt + y_0\mu(x_0)\right).$$

□

3.3.2 Global Existence

Definition 3.4

A solution $y(x)$ of the IVP

$$y' + P(x)y = Q(x), \quad y(x_0) = y_0$$

is said to have *global existence* if it exists for all $x \in \mathbb{R}$.

Remark

Why global existence holds for linear equations but not necessarily for nonlinear ones.

Contrast with the nonlinear case. For the nonlinear IVP

$$y' = y^2, y(0) = 1$$

the solution is

$$y = \frac{1}{1-x}$$

which blows up at $x = 1$, even though $f(x, y) = y^2$ is perfectly smooth everywhere. Solutions of nonlinear equations can escape to infinity in finite time, even when f is analytic.
For the linear case

$$y' + P(x)y = Q(x)$$

with P, Q continuous on $\mathbb{R}$, the solution exists for all $x \in \mathbb{R}$. Global existence is guaranteed.

3.3.3 The General Solution is Complete

Definition 3.5

The general solution of a linear first-order differential equation

$$y' + P(x)y = Q(x)$$

is complete in the sense that it contains all possible solutions. Any solution can be obtained by choosing an appropriate constant C in the general solution

$$y = \frac{1}{\mu(x)} \left(\int_{x_0}^{x} \mu(t)Q(t)\, dt + C \right),$$

where $\mu(x) = e^{\int P(x)\, dx}$ is the integrating factor.

3.4 Applications

3.4.1 R-C Circuit

Consider an R-C circuit with a resistor R and a capacitor C in series, connected to a voltage source $V(t)$. The governing equation for the charge $q(t)$ on the capacitor is

$$R\frac{dq}{dt} + \frac{q}{C} = V(t).$$

This is a linear first-order differential equation of the form

$$q' + \frac{1}{RC}q = \frac{V(t)}{R}.$$

This is a first-order linear ODE with $P = 1/(RC)$ and $Q = V(t)/R$.

3.4.2 Mixing Problem

Consider a tank initially containing V_0 liters of brine with a salt concentration of C_0 grams per liter. Brine with a concentration of C_{in} grams per liter flows into the tank at a rate of r_{in} liters per minute, and the well-mixed solution flows out at a rate of r_{out} liters per minute. Let $C(t)$ denote the concentration of salt in the tank at time t. The governing equation is

$$V_0\frac{dC}{dt} = r_{\text{in}}C_{\text{in}} - r_{\text{out}}C.$$

This is a linear first-order differential equation of the form

$$C' + \frac{r_{\text{out}}}{V_0}C = \frac{r_{\text{in}}C_{\text{in}}}{V_0}.$$

This is a first-order linear ODE with $P = r_{\text{out}}/V_0$ and $Q = r_{\text{in}}C_{\text{in}}/V_0$.

3.5 Summary

3.5.1 Topic

Topic	Key condition	Result
Picard–Lindelöf	f continuous + Lipschitz in y	Local existence and uniqueness
Separable equations	$y' = g(x)h(y)$	Separate, integrate, check equilibria
Homogeneous	$y' = F(y/x)$	Substitute $v = y/x$, separable
Bernoulli	$y' + Py = Qy^n$	Substitute $w = y^{1-n}$, linearise
Linear + integrating factor	P, Q continuous on I	$\mu = e^{\int \mathrm{d}x P}$, global solution
Linear existence & uniqueness	P, Q continuous on I	Unique solution on all of I

3.5.2 Picture

ODEs can be broadly classified into linear and nonlinear types.

On the general side, we have local existence and uniqueness under the Picard-Lindelöf conditions, It have such Complex behaviour, including possible finite-time blow-up and non-uniqueness.

On the linear side, we have explicit global solutions using the integrating factor method and a sharp uniqueness theorem. Where the P and Q are continuous, the solution exists and is unique on the entire interval.

The linear case is much simpler case and easier to handle analytically.

4 Lecture 4: Several Variable Calculus

Example

Temperature in this room:

$$T = T(x, y, z) \quad \text{temperature field}$$

a three-variable function of x, y, z.

4.1 Function of Several Variables

4.1.1 Scalar fields

Definition 4.1

Let $D \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$. A real function of n variables

$$f \colon D \to \mathbb{R}$$
$$(x_1, x_2, \ldots, x_n) \mapsto z = f(x_1, x_2, \ldots, x_n) \in \mathbb{R}$$

is called a *scalar field*.

Remark

It is a linear functional of its arguments if it is linear.

Example

For the 2-dimensional case, a scalar field is a function

$$f \colon D \subseteq \mathbb{R}^2 \to \mathbb{R}$$
$$(x, y) \mapsto f(x, y)$$

4.1.2 Level sets

Definition 4.2

The *level set* at value c of f is the set

$$\{(x_1, x_2, \ldots, x_n) \in D \mid f(x_1, x_2, \ldots, x_n) = c\}.$$

Example

Consider the potential field

$$V(r) = \frac{1}{r}.$$

Then

$$\begin{aligned} V(x_1, x_2, x_3) &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{x_1^2 + x_2^2 + x_3^2}} \\ &= \left(\sum_{i=1}^{3} x_i^2 \right)^{-\frac{1}{2}}. \end{aligned}$$

The level sets of this potential field satisfy

$$V(x_1, x_2, x_3) = c \implies \left(\sum_{i=1}^{3} x_i^2 \right)^{\frac{1}{2}} = c^{-1}.$$

Three variables and one equation give just one degree of freedom, which corresponds to a 2-dimensional surface in $\mathbb{R}^3$.

4.2 Partial Derivatives

4.2.1 First order partial derivatives

Definition 4.3

The partial derivative of $f(x, y)$ with respect to x is defined as

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial f}{\partial x} = \lim_{\epsilon \to 0} \frac{f(x + \epsilon, y) - f(x, y)}{\epsilon} &= f_x(x, y) \\ &= \frac{\partial f}{\partial x}(x, y) = \frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\Big|_{(x,y)} \end{aligned}$$

if the limit exists.

$$\iff f(x + \epsilon, y) = f(x, y) + \epsilon f_x(x, y) + \mathcal{O}(\epsilon^2).$$

The partial derivative of $f(x, y)$ with respect to y is defined similarly:

$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial y} = \lim_{\epsilon \to 0} \frac{f(x, y + \epsilon) - f(x, y)}{\epsilon} = f_y(x, y) = \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}(x, y) = \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\Big|_{(x,y)}.$$

Proof.

$$\begin{aligned} \lim_{\epsilon \to 0} \frac{f(x, y) + \epsilon f_x(x, y) + \mathcal{O}(\epsilon^2) - f(x, y)}{\epsilon} &= \lim_{\epsilon \to 0} \frac{\epsilon f_x(x, y) + \mathcal{O}(\epsilon^2)}{\epsilon} \\ &= \lim_{\epsilon \to 0} \left(f_x(x, y) + \mathcal{O}(\epsilon) \right) \\ &= f_x(x, y). \end{aligned}$$

□

Example

Let

$$f(x,y) = x^3 y + \sin(xy).$$

Then

$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial x} = 3x^2 y + y\cos(xy),$$
$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial y} = x^3 + x\cos(xy).$$

4.2.2 Higher order partial derivatives

Definition 4.4

The second order partial derivatives of $f(x,y)$ are

$$f_{xx} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\right), \quad f_{yy} = \frac{\partial}{\partial y}\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\right), \quad f_{xy} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\right), \quad f_{yx} = \frac{\partial}{\partial y}\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\right).$$

Theorem 4.1

Schwarz's theorem

If f_{xy} and f_{yx} exist and are continuous on D, then

$$f_{xy}(x,y) = f_{yx}(x,y) \qquad \forall (x,y) \in D.$$

4.3 Gradient

4.3.1 Gradient

Definition 4.5

The gradient of f is the vector of its first-order partial derivatives:

$$\nabla f = \left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_1}, \ldots, \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_n}\right) \in \mathbb{R}^n,$$

an n-dimensional vector.

We have

$$\begin{aligned} f(x+\Delta x, y+\Delta y) &= f(x, y+\Delta y) + f_x(x, y+\Delta y)\Delta x + \mathcal{O}(\Delta x) \\ &= f(x,y) + f_y(x,y)\Delta y + \mathcal{O}(\Delta y^2) \\ &\quad + f_x(x,y)\Delta x + f_{xy}(x,y)\Delta x \Delta y + \mathcal{O}(\Delta x^2) \\ &= f(x,y) + [f_x(x,y)\Delta x + f_y(x,y)\Delta y] + \mathcal{O}(\epsilon^2), \end{aligned}$$

where $\Delta x, \Delta y \sim \epsilon$.
More generally

$$\begin{aligned} f(x_1+\Delta x_1, \ldots, x_n+\Delta x_n) - f(x_1, \ldots, x_n) &= \sum_{i=1}^{n} \left.\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_i}\right|_{(x_1,\ldots,x_n)} \Delta x_i + \mathcal{O}(\epsilon^2) \\ &= \Delta f(x_1, \ldots, x_n). \end{aligned}$$

Let $\vec{x} = (x_1, \ldots, x_n)$.

Definition 4.6

The total differential of f is

$$df = \sum_{j=1}^{n} \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j}\, dx_j,$$

where $dx_i = \Delta x_i$. Thus

$$\begin{aligned} df &= \sum_{j=1}^{n} \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j}\, dx_j \\ &= \nabla f \cdot d\vec{x}. \end{aligned}$$

4.3.2 Total Differential

Definition 4.7

The total differential of a function f at a point $\vec{x} = (x_1, \ldots, x_n)$ is the linear approximation of the change in f given by

$$df = \sum_{j=1}^{n} \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j} dx_j.$$

4.3.3 Infinitesimal variation in direction $\vec{u}$

Assume $\|\vec{u}\| = 1$. Then

$$\Delta f = f(\vec{x} + \epsilon\vec{u}) - f(\vec{x}).$$

This is no different from hiking a mountain along the direction of $\vec{u}$.

$$\begin{aligned} \Delta f &= f(\vec{x} + \epsilon\vec{u}) - f(\vec{x}) \\ &= \epsilon \left[\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_1} u_1 + \cdots + \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_n} u_n \right] + \mathcal{O}(\epsilon^2) \\ &= \epsilon \nabla f \cdot \vec{u} + \mathcal{O}(\epsilon^2). \end{aligned}$$

The directional derivative is

$$D_{\vec{u}} f(\vec{x}) = \lim_{\epsilon \to 0} \frac{f(\vec{x} + \epsilon\vec{u}) - f(\vec{x})}{\epsilon} = \nabla f \cdot \vec{u} \quad \text{(a scalar)}.$$

Properties

where θ is the angle between ∇f and $\vec{u}$.

$$\nabla f \cdot \vec{u} = \|\nabla f\| \cos\theta,$$

So the gradient points in the direction of the steepest ascent of the function.

1. Maximum value when $\vec{u}$ is along ∇f.
2. ∇f is orthogonal to the tangent to the level set.

4.3.4 The Chain Rule

Definition 4.8

For $n = 2$, let $f(x, y)$, $x(t)$, $y(t)$, and

$$F(t) = f(x(t), y(t))$$

Then

$$\frac{dF}{dt} = \lim_{\epsilon \to 0} \frac{F(t+\epsilon) - F(t)}{\epsilon} = \frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\frac{dx}{dt} + \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\frac{dy}{dt}$$

Generalize to n
let

$$f(x_1, \ldots, x_n), \quad x_i = x_i(t)$$

Then

$$\frac{df}{dt} = \sum_{j=1}^{n} \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j}\frac{dx_j}{dt} = \nabla f \cdot \dot{\vec{x}}(t)$$

where $\dot{\vec{x}}(t) = \frac{d\vec{x}}{dt}$.

For $n = 2$, let

$$x = x(s, t)$$
$$y = y(s, t)$$

and define

$$F(s, t) = f(x(s, t), y(s, t))$$

This transforms points from the (x, y)-plane to the (s, t)-plane.

Notation

In physics notation,

$$\frac{\partial F}{\partial s} = \text{“}\frac{\partial f}{\partial s}\text{”}.$$

We have

$$\begin{cases} \dfrac{\partial F}{\partial s} = \dfrac{\partial f}{\partial x}\dfrac{\partial x}{\partial s} + \dfrac{\partial f}{\partial y}\dfrac{\partial y}{\partial s} \\ \dfrac{\partial F}{\partial t} = \dfrac{\partial f}{\partial x}\dfrac{\partial x}{\partial t} + \dfrac{\partial f}{\partial y}\dfrac{\partial y}{\partial t} \end{cases}$$

Generalize to n: let $(x_1, \ldots, x_n) \to (\xi_1, \ldots, \xi_n)$, with

$$\begin{cases} x_1 = x_1(\xi_1, \ldots, \xi_n) \\ x_2 = x_2(\xi_1, \ldots, \xi_n) \\ \quad \vdots \\ x_n = x_n(\xi_1, \ldots, \xi_n) \end{cases}$$

Then

$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial \xi_i} = \sum_{k=1}^{n} \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_k}\frac{\partial x_k}{\partial \xi_i} = \sum_{k=1}^{n} (\nabla f)_k J_{ik}$$

$$\underbrace{\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_k}}_{\substack{\text{component of } \nabla f \\ \text{n-dim vector}}} \qquad \underbrace{\frac{\partial x_k}{\partial \xi_i}}_{\substack{\text{component of } J \\ \text{n-dim vector}}}$$

and

$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_i} = \sum_{k=1}^{n} (J^{-1})_{ik} \frac{\partial f}{\partial \xi_k}$$

Definition 4.9

The Jacobian matrix

$$J_{ik} = \frac{\partial x_k}{\partial \xi_i}$$

i.e.

$$J = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{\partial x_1}{\partial \xi_1} & \cdots & \frac{\partial x_n}{\partial \xi_1} \\ \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ \frac{\partial x_1}{\partial \xi_n} & \cdots & \frac{\partial x_n}{\partial \xi_n} \end{pmatrix}_{n \times n}$$

Matrix-vector relations can be written as

$$\vec{v} = M \cdot \vec{w}, \qquad \vec{w} = M^{-1} \cdot \vec{v}$$

Example

Take (x_1, x_2), and we can also use (r, θ) to describe it, where

$$\begin{cases} x_1 = r\cos\theta \\ x_2 = r\sin\theta \end{cases}$$

Then

$$J = \begin{pmatrix} J_{11} & J_{12} \\ J_{21} & J_{22} \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{\partial x_1}{\partial r} & \frac{\partial x_1}{\partial \theta} \\ \frac{\partial x_2}{\partial r} & \frac{\partial x_2}{\partial \theta} \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} \cos\theta & -r\sin\theta \\ \sin\theta & r\cos\theta \end{pmatrix}$$